

PERENTIE*Varanus giganteus*

The largest lizard in Australia, this shy species inhabits arid regions. It has a varied diet and mildly venomous saliva.

spotted pattern of scales

2.5 m
8 ftstrong claws for
digging out prey2 m
6½ ft**NILE MONITOR***Varanus niloticus*

The second largest reptile in Africa, this monitor preys on various vertebrates and molluscs, and also scavenges on carrion.

GREEN TREE MONITOR*Varanus prasinus*

This monitor from New Guinea feeds on invertebrates in the forest canopy. A prehensile tail and sticky feet help it to grip branches.

75–100 cm
30–39 in**YELLOW-SPOTTED MONITOR***Varanus panoptes*

This species from Australia and S. New Guinea is rarely found far from a permanent source of water. It preys on other reptiles.

1.4 m
4½ ftskin folds
on neck**KOMODO DRAGON***Varanus komodoensis*

The world's largest lizard, this species is restricted to a few Indonesian islands. It is a formidable predator of large mammals.

3 m
10 ftwell-developed,
strong limbsgreyish brown
scaly skin

AMPHISBAENIANS

They may resemble legless lizards, but the burrowing reptiles in the suborder **Amphisbaenia** are quite distinct in their anatomy and behaviour.

The amphisbaenians, or worm-lizards, are reptiles wholly adapted to a subterranean lifestyle, spending almost their entire lives underground. Most species have lost all trace of their limbs and have elongated bodies with smooth scales.

They hunt for soil invertebrates by means of scent and sound, killing them in their crushing jaws. Burrowing involves the worm-lizard propelling itself forward by contracting and extending its body while the specially adapted head pushes through the soil. The eyes are protected by tough, translucent skin. Fertilization is internal, with some species laying eggs, others bearing live young. They are found in South America, Florida, Africa, the Middle East, and southern Europe.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	REPTILIA
ORDER	SQUAMATA
FAMILIES (AMPHISBAENIANS)	6
SPECIES	195

WORM-LIZARDS

Amphisbaenians are burrowing reptiles with a head specially adapted for digging. They are found in Europe, sub-Saharan Africa and South America. They are formidable predators of soil invertebrates, hunting by scent and sound.

EUROPEAN WORM-LIZARD*Blanus cinereus*

Rarely seen above ground, this burrowing reptile from Spain and Morocco forages in leaf litter for invertebrates, particularly ants.

30 cm
12 inblack and
white markings**SPECKLED WORM-LIZARD***Amphisbaena fuliginosa*

This worm-lizard hunts invertebrates while burrowing through leaf litter in the rainforests of S. America. It surfaces during heavy rains.

45 cm
18 inrudimentary
eye**LANG'S ROUND-HEADED WORM-LIZARD***Chirindia langi*

Found in southern Africa, this species burrows through sandy soils to forage for termites. If caught, it can shed its tail in a bid to escape.

17 cm
6½ in